



Cimply — Product Requirements Document

Writing sample — Cimply is a demonstration scheduling product for creative studios, built to showcase documentation and requirements-writing skills. Not a live commercial product.

This is a curated excerpt of a longer internal PRD (v1.3, ~6,000 words spanning the full v1 feature set). It includes the problem framing, goals and scoping decisions, and a complete deep-dive on the product's core mechanic — Order & Status System Design — narrative design rationale plus the acceptance-criteria requirements it produced. User & Account Management, a smaller and less frequently used part of the system, is summarized rather than reproduced in full; it's the subject of a companion case study, "Facilitating a Requirements Deep-Dive on Cimply's PRD," which walks through how several of its decisions were made. Full document available on request.

Problem Statement

Small creative agencies, design studios, and in-house creative teams have no dedicated tool for managing how work gets assigned to and executed by their designers. Schedulers — creative directors, studio ops, or project managers — currently manage this through a mix of Google Calendar, Slack messages, and spreadsheets to match incoming client work to available designer time. The result is scattered context, lost communication, and no shared view of where any given order stands. Designers receive fragmented instructions with no single place to ask questions, confirm their assignments, or log what they actually did. Without a purpose-built system, both sides waste time on coordination overhead that should be spent on creative work.

Goals

1. **Reduce scheduler coordination overhead** — schedulers spend less than 15 minutes per week chasing status updates on active orders, down from a baseline established in beta.
2. **Give designers clarity on their work** — 90% of designers report knowing exactly what is expected of them before starting an order, measured via post-launch survey.
3. **Centralize order communication** — 80% of order-related back-and-forth happens inside Cimply orders rather than email or Slack, measured by self-report in onboarding survey at 30 days.
4. **Establish a time record** — every completed order has an actualized time entry logged by the designer before it closes.
5. **Achieve activation in small studios** — at least one order created, assigned, and completed end-to-end within the first 7 days for 70% of new accounts in beta.

Non-Goals

For v1, Cimply will NOT:



- **Schedule equipment or physical spaces.** Rooms, cameras, edit suites, and other non-human resources are out of scope. The product focuses exclusively on people. *(Rationale: Adds significant data modeling complexity; not needed to validate the core two-sided order workflow.)*
- **Record multiple designers working on the same order.** Each order has exactly one assigned designer. *(Rationale: Keeps the order model simple — one owner, one time estimate, one actualized-hours entry. Splitting work across multiple designers on a single order is a data modeling problem for a later version; for v1, split it into separate orders instead.)*
- **Support self-assignment from an open pool.** Designers will not browse and claim unassigned orders in v1. All orders are assigned by the scheduler. *(Rationale: Requires status-gating and permission logic that complicates v1; validated as a backlog feature.)*
- **Process payments.** In-app payment to designers is a future goal, not a v1 feature. *(Rationale: Requires financial infrastructure, compliance, and trust-building premature before core adoption.)*
- **Function as a freelance marketplace or discovery platform.** Cimplify supports freelance designers the same way it supports in-house staff — invited into a studio's account, assigned work, tracked identically — but it doesn't connect studios with freelancers they don't already have a relationship with, and has no public profiles, matching, or discovery mechanics. *(Rationale: Marketplace dynamics — trust, discovery, two-sided onboarding between strangers — are a different product problem than the one Cimplify solves; Cimplify assumes the studio and designer already know each other.)*
- **Detect or prevent scheduling overlaps for a designer.** Two orders can be assigned to the same designer with overlapping time windows with no system warning in v1. *(Rationale: Overlap detection requires a Work Type/exclusivity concept that isn't defined yet; scheduler judgment covers this for now given how small these teams typically are.)*
- **Integrate with external project management tools in v1.** No Asana, Jira, or Notion sync at launch. *(Rationale: Integrations add surface area; establish core workflow first.)*
- **Support a dedicated account Owner tier.** Admin privileges are sufficient for v1; there is no non-revocable owner role tied to billing. *(Rationale: No in-app billing or payments in v1; the last-admin protection rule already prevents an account from losing all administrative access.)*
- **Allow self-service signup for additional users.** All Scheduler and Designer accounts are created via Admin-issued invite; there is no public registration flow. *(Rationale: Keeps account membership controlled by the studio, consistent with Cimplify's role as an internal ops tool.)*
- **Support hard deletion of Active or Suspended users.** Once a user has ever logged in, their account can only be suspended, not deleted, to preserve order and message history. Only a still-Pending (never-activated) invite can be deleted outright. *(Rationale: Historical attribution on orders and messages is a core product principle; hard-deleting an active or suspended user would orphan that history.)*
- **Export data out of Cimplify.** No CSV export, reporting exports, or API access to pull orders, time logs, or user data out of the product in v1. *(Rationale: Reduces v1 surface*



area — the dashboards are the only way to view data for now, which is enough to validate the core workflow before investing in export/reporting infrastructure.)

User Personas

The Scheduler

A creative director, studio ops lead, or project manager at a small creative agency or in-house team. Responsible for matching incoming client work to available designer capacity. Small studios typically have 1–3 people in this role. Needs visibility into who is working on what, what is in progress, and what has been completed.

The Designer (Resource)

A staff or regular-contract graphic designer, motion artist, or other creative professional. Has a finite number of working hours that need to be filled with the right work. Needs clear instructions, a way to communicate questions back without a Slack thread, and a record of what they completed.

Admin (Scheduler Privilege)

Admin is a permission flag layered on top of the Scheduler role, not a separate dashboard or persona. The role can be held by one or more Schedulers on an account. Responsible for inviting and managing users, assigning Scheduler/Designer roles, and granting Admin privileges to other Schedulers — see the summary near the end of this excerpt.

Deep-Dive: Order & Status System Design

The order is the product’s core object — this is where Schedulers and Designers spend their day. Reproduced below in full: narrative design rationale, followed by the acceptance-criteria requirements it produced.

What an Order Holds

Each order carries a title, a work brief, an estimated-hours figure, and a scheduled start and end date/time — a full window rather than a single due date, so both sides can see when work is expected to happen, not just when it’s due. A Designer can be assigned at creation or left unassigned, since a Scheduler often needs to log incoming work before capacity is confirmed. Every order also tracks its primary Scheduler (who owns it) and, once work wraps, the Designer’s actualized hours.

Status Lifecycle

Status carries an order through its life. Complete and Cancelled are terminal: once reached, the order’s fields and status lock permanently — though the message thread stays open for both parties to keep posting.

Status	What it means
New	Created, not yet assigned to a Designer.
Assigned	A Designer is attached; work hasn’t started.
In Progress	Designer is actively working.



Status	What it means
On Hold	Paused, waiting on something.
Needs Review	Designer submitted; Scheduler needs to look at it.
Complete	Closed successfully. Terminal — locked.
Cancelled	Closed without completion. Terminal — locked.

Who Can Move What

Status changes are permission-gated — not every role can set every status:

Action	Scheduler	Designer
Move to any status	✓	—
Move to In Progress	✓	✓
Move to On Hold	✓	✓
Move to Needs Review	✓	✓
Move to Complete	✓	—
Move to New or Assigned	✓	—
Move to Cancelled	✓	—

Reassignment & Cancellation

- Orders in New or Assigned status: Scheduler can freely reassign to a different Designer.
- Orders In Progress, On Hold, Needs Review, or Complete: reassignment is blocked — the Scheduler cancels and creates a new order instead.
- Exception: if the assigned Designer is suspended or has changed roles, the order is flagged and reassignment unlocks regardless of status — except Complete or Cancelled, which stay terminal.

To cancel, a Scheduler moves the order to Cancelled and posts a message explaining why — a lightweight convention in v1 that becomes a required field later. The order locks immediately; history and the message thread remain open.

Visual Flags

Two flags surface timing problems automatically, with no Scheduler action required. Past-Due appears once an order's end date passes without reaching a terminal status. Late Start appears once an order's start date passes while it's still New or Assigned — work hasn't begun on schedule. If both conditions are true at once, Past-Due takes precedence; the two flags never show together.

Corresponding P0 Requirements

The same feature area, written in the acceptance-criteria format used for the full requirements list handed to engineering.

Order Creation



- Scheduler can create a new order with title, work brief, estimated hours, and a scheduled start and end date/time. Assigning a Designer is optional at creation — an order can be created unassigned and stays in New status until a Designer is assigned.
- New order auto-sets to New status on creation.
- Order records who created and last modified it, and when, on every save.

Acceptance criteria: Order is saved and immediately visible on the Scheduler's dashboard. If a Designer is assigned at creation, it's also immediately visible on their dashboard.

Order Assignment

- Scheduler can assign any order to a Designer or a Scheduler on the team roster — the two roles are not mutually exclusive for assignment purposes.
- Assigning a Designer to an order in New status moves it to Assigned status.
- Orders in New or Assigned status can be reassigned freely. Orders in any other status cannot be.

Acceptance criteria: Designer receives an email notification on first assignment. Order appears in the Designer's queue.

Order Status Lifecycle

- Orders move through statuses according to the permission model above.
- Complete and Cancelled are terminal — no further changes once reached.
- Every status change is timestamped and attributed to the user who made it.

Acceptance criteria: Unauthorized status transitions are blocked server-side. Both parties see current status and who last changed it.

Cancellation

- Scheduler can move any non-terminal order to Cancelled status.

Acceptance criteria: Order is immediately locked after cancellation. History remains visible, and the message thread stays open for both parties to continue posting.

Visual Flags (Past-Due & Late Start)

- Any order whose end date/time has passed and is not in a terminal status displays a Past-Due indicator.
- Any order whose start date/time has passed while still New or Assigned displays a Late Start indicator, distinct from Past-Due.
- If both conditions are true, Past-Due takes precedence — the two flags aren't shown together.

Acceptance criteria: Flags appear automatically with no Scheduler action required, and clear the moment the triggering condition resolves.



User & Account Management (Summary)

Cimply also has an Admin & User Account Management layer — inviting users, assigning roles, suspending access — that got a full requirements pass of its own. In short:

- Admin is a permission flag on top of the Scheduler role, not a separate persona or dashboard. Any Scheduler can hold it, and multiple Admins are supported per account.
- Users move through pending → active → suspended states. Once someone has ever logged in, suspension — not deletion — is the only offboarding path, so order and message history is never orphaned.
- A last-admin protection rule guarantees an account can never lose all administrative access — the flag can't be removed, and the holder can't be suspended or role-changed, if they're the only Admin left.

Full requirements-level detail — invitation, suspension, role change, and their acceptance criteria — is covered in the companion case study, “Facilitating a Requirements Deep-Dive on Cimply’s PRD,” and in the full PRD, available on request.

Full PRD — complete User & Account Management requirements, Success Metrics, and Timeline — available on request.